Truth be told, my mind was in other places for much of the time Leif was chasing us back and forth across Australia. I had always liked taking machines and pulling them apart and rebuilding them. It was, I suppose, a technical instinct, and I was keen not just to push appliances around or switch them on but to understand them. After the departure of Brett the first period of my life was over and I was ready for some heady advancement. I noticed, in a shop in Lismore, a fascinating new machine that instantly spoke to me of something new. It stood in the window: the Commodore 64 computer.

To modern eyes that computer looks laughably primitive, a chunky, boxy mass of grey plastic that ran on disks more than twice the size of the phone in my pocket with less than one-hundred-thousandth of the capacity. You could look at it now and say that it resembled a cast-off from a *Star Trek* set, a childish impression of what the future might look like. But the thing is, to someone like me in a small town in Australia, this really was the future, and I wanted to understand it.

By the time I was sixteen, the computer had become my consciousness. It was the beginning of a new life. Not that the old life didn't have sway – it did, and still does – but in some way it was the computer I spoke with, or spoke through, reaching past all local concerns to an infinity point where selfhood dissolves into history. Later on, the question of selfhood, or my selfhood, would come to obsess many sections of the press. Was I arrogant or crazy, careless or manipulative, touchy or thin-skinned or tyrannical? But the self they were talking about was in their heads. It was part of their fantasy. I was trying to do my work under pressure and wasn't much aware of myself at all, not in the sense they mean. People nowadays love the play of selfhood: they think everything is a soap opera. But I mean what I say when I say my 'self' lies somewhere behind me: with a computer, and a lifetime's project, you no longer find yourself chasing from pillar to post the small business of yourself. You disappear into something larger and you serve it as best you can.

Maybe it was a generational thing. And some don't get it. They want to stuff you into their old fictional categories: of being Billy the Kid or Dr No, of being Robin Hood or Dr Strangelove. But I believe a generation came of age in the late 1980s that didn't think like that. We were weaned on computers, and we didn't reckon on 'selfhood': we reckoned on 'us', and, if at all possible, 'us and them'. When it comes to computers, the cliché was